

Project Description Philosophy of Science

This project allows you to achieve extra depth on one of the topics of this course.

Project timeline and instructions for hand-in:

1. **Draft of the project (different from the project proposal).** Although this is not graded, we recommend that you hand it in for first feedback about the first draft. The draft may be partial.
 - Include: topic title, abstract, table of contents (under each item: brief description and references), list of references, and substantial text in draft version.
Submission: on Canvas, **one submission per group.**
2. **Final version.** At the end of October *at the latest*.
 - Most students normally prefer submit the project at the end of October, by the deadline.
 - Some students prefer to submit it early, shortly after the exam. This is also completely acceptable to us. The submission page is open until the deadline.
 - **Submission:** on Canvas, **one submission per group.**

Choice of topic:

- Take an **existing discussion in the philosophical literature** as your starting point. To this end, we suggest that you have a look at the content of the whole course and identify a topic of your interest.
- We also recommend to consult the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (SEP) page on your topic, and other philosophical journals such as *Synthese*, *Studies in History and Philosophy of Science*, *Philosophy of Science*, *European Journal for Philosophy of Science*, *The British Journal for the Philosophy of Science*, *Erkenntnis*, etc.
- Writers of popular science literature and articles for a broadly interested philosophical audience, or scientists who write about philosophy, in principle **do not qualify as philosophical literature**. They may be used and cited, but they should not be your main topic. The philosophical discussion is carried out in **philosophical journals** like the ones cited above.

The Paper

You write (in a group, or individually) a philosophical paper about one of the topics of your choice of the course.

Length: around 4000-7000 words per student (8-15 pages), all inclusive. This is only an indication.

For how a philosophy paper should look like, have a look at some of the papers we have read in the course, and also at the sample papers on Canvas (this year's papers are from the course Philosophy of Physics, but they do give you an indication of how to write, structure etc.). There is also a writing workshop where you will get tips and have the opportunity to ask questions.

Marking criteria

1. Good understanding and explanation of the ideas and arguments in the original text(s).

2. Structure: the structure of the paper reflects the structure of your argument.
3. Development of the thesis: argumentation, lack of logical gaps.
4. Clarity and precision of the thesis and the argumentation.
5. Difficulty and originality.

(Standard minimal requirements: submitted by the deadline, correct spelling and grammar, no plagiarism).

Note: 10% of the mark for your paper will be based on the formative components of the assessment: discussion of your project idea, your project proposal, your incorporation of feedback, and your first draft.

Further comments

- **Audience:** write for an audience of (imaginary) fellow students who did not follow this course or do the readings, but who are generally engaged in philosophy of science.
- Does the **topic** contain a unified single question (so that you can go in depth) or is the paper too ambitious in its scope (so that it contains too many claims that have not been properly justified)? This is a key skill that we want to you learn. Without this, you cannot get a higher grade than a 7.
- The fifth marking criterium: difficulty and originality.
It is possible to write a good paper and get an 8 if you describe, in your own words, an existing question, debate or line of reasoning in an insightful and clear way.
To get a higher grade, you should contribute something—even if small—to the current debates. Please note: you should still engage with the extant discussions in the literature. You will not reach a higher level of difficulty or of originality by just doing things your way, i.e. you need to engage with the key arguments in the field. Thus you can e.g. try to further explicate a difficult problem or observation they made, or apply their view to a new case or problem, and draw surprising conclusions from that application.
- Use the APA citation style (<https://www.mendeley.com/guides/apa-citation-guide>) or similar. When you cite a paper, give, in the main text, also the pages you are citing. So, for example, rather than writing 'This is described in Jones (1985)', you write 'This is described in Jones (1985: pp. 175-176)', or something along these lines.
- Make explicit any limitations of the scope of your argumentation.
- Argument reconstruction in terms of premises and conclusion (P1, P2, C) can sometimes be useful to structure and limit your discussion (e.g. 'In this paper, I will accept the premise P1, but argue against P2'). If you decide to do this, state your reconstruction in a valid form. Valid forms include modus ponens and modus tollens.
- More about philosophical writing:
https://philosophy.fas.harvard.edu/files/phildept/files/brief_guide_to_writing_philosophy_paper.pdf

About the use of AI tools:

- The work you submit must be your own. All conceptual analysis, interpretations, and philosophical arguments must be authored by you.
- Use of AI tools is permitted but not encouraged. If you use them, include an 'AI use statement' at the end of your submission specifying the tool(s), the purpose(s), and the extent of assistance.
- Permitted uses: improving clarity and grammar; refining phrasing; brainstorming and contextualising ideas; locating relevant papers or concepts, as with a search engine.

- Not permitted: generating or structuring your arguments or analysis; submitting AI-generated text as your own; fabricating references or quotations.
- You are responsible for verifying the accuracy of all content and citations. Do not include personal or confidential data in prompts.
- Any use must comply with the UvA *Regulations Governing Fraud and Plagiarism* (2019). Misuse will be treated as academic misconduct.